

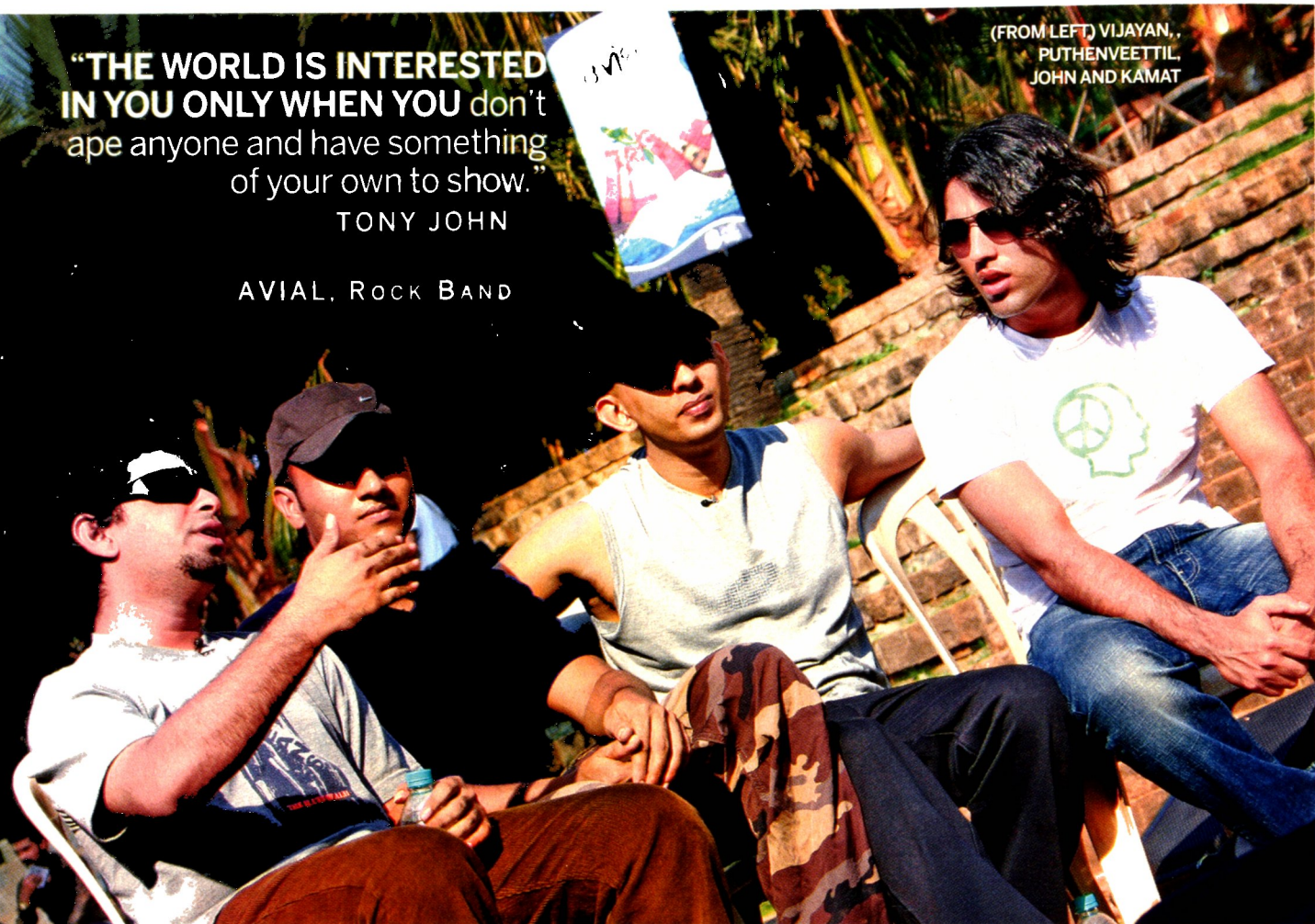


**"THE WORLD IS INTERESTED
IN YOU ONLY WHEN YOU** don't
ape anyone and have something
of your own to show."

TONY JOHN

AVIAL, ROCK BAND

(FROM LEFT) VIJAYAN,
PUTHENVEETIL,
JOHN AND KAMAT



The usual western music-fixated crowd in Kerala dismissed them as kooky when they started talking about Malayalam rock. They could just about think of Tamil rock. But rock music in Malayalam with its highly complex word structure? Nah. Yet Tony John, 37, and his small band of rock zealots had no such doubts. Five years after its birth, Avial (a traditional Kerala mixed vegetable "fusion" dish) today has emerged as one of the most talked about alternative rock bands in the country. Singing only Malayalam music, including traditional songs favoured by farmers, the band hit the big league this year when their first album Avial swept the prestigious Jack Daniel Rock awards in three categories. The four-member team—comprising John, vocals; Rex Vijayan, 27, guitar; Mithun Puthenveetil, 27, drums; and Naresh Kamat, 35, bass—won the award for the best band, song of the year as well as the album of the year. "All of us used to sing English rock. But during a trip abroad, wisdom dawned on us and we realised that what the world wanted from us was our own music and cultural expres-

sions," says John. This prompted the team to look inwards and explore their own tradition. "We were ashamed not to have been familiar with such treasures lying in our own backyard until then," says Puthenveetil. "We then dedicated ourselves to completing our first album. It took us more than two years to release it," he says.

Avial is now getting invites from all over the country and abroad. It is just back after a string of successful concerts in Mauritius and the Reunion Islands, where the audience was dominated by the local community. Another indicator of its universal appeal came recently when a Naples-based rock band A 67 commissioned the band to participate in their latest album after hearing it on MySpace. They are now earnestly looking forward to the ongoing international online poll to find the world's best rock bands, conducted by a website run by rock buffs from around the world. The top 20 bands will be invited to a grand concert to be held Las Vegas. As of now, Avial is at No. 18 and looking to rise. Just like their music.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

Turning Point

When they released their first album Avial. It took two years to complete the album, which was produced and mixed in Karma Audios run by the band.